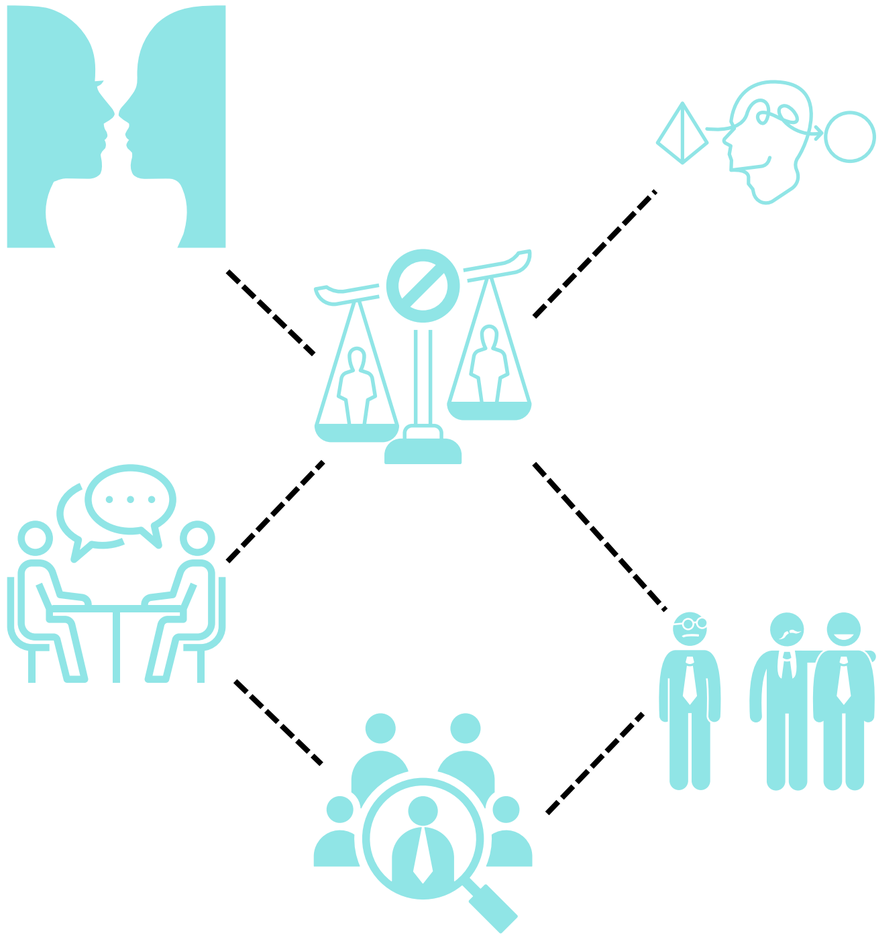
Perceptual Biases In Hiring



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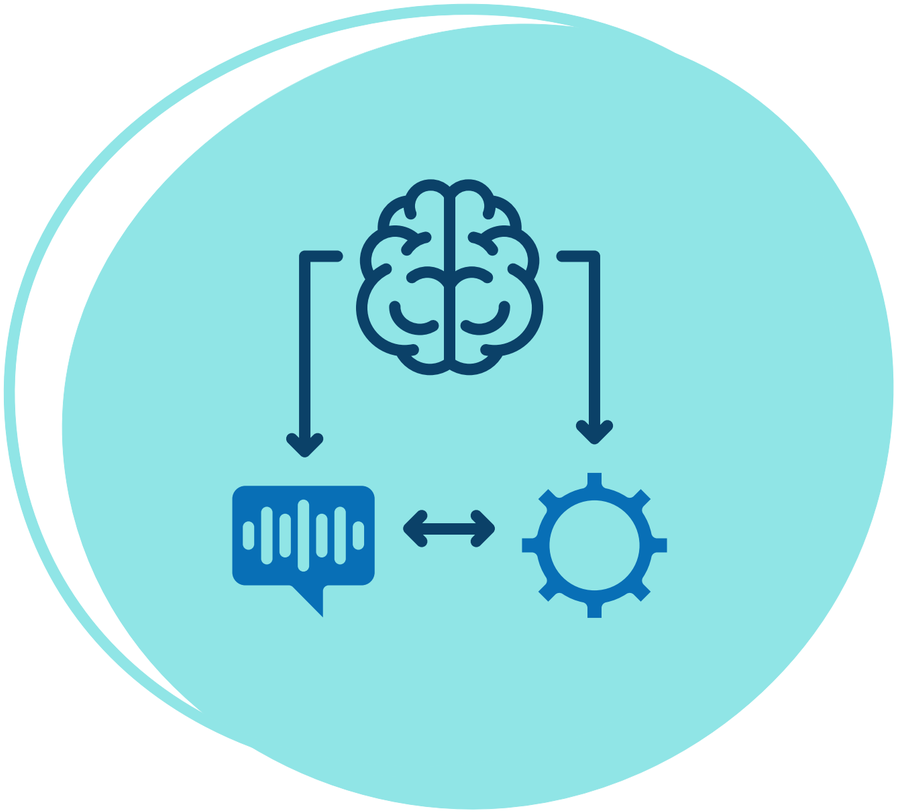
What is Perception?

The process of **receiving information** about and **making sense** of the world around us.



(McShane & Von Glinow, 2023)

Identity

”Who am I” & “Who are we”

how others see me (or us) and how I want others to see me (or us)

“What is my reason for being?”

(Pratt & Hedden, 2023)

Perceptual errors and biases

STEREOTYPING

Stereotyping characteristics or attributes applied to a group of people as the result of accepted beliefs that are held about that specific group (Koch et al., 2015).

HALO EFFECT

occurs when people project one specific (usually positive) characteristic of a person onto the other qualities of that person (Mondy and Martocchio, 2016).

STATUS QUO BASIS

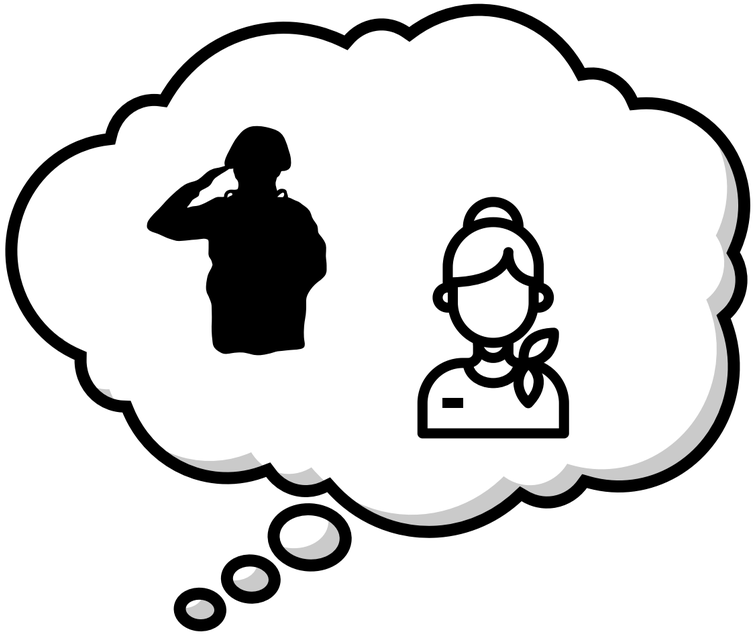
present when people stick to the status quo rather than opting for a potentially better solution that requires change (Samuelson and Zeckhauser, 1988).

PEAK END RULE

implies that people tend only to remember the peak or the end of an experience and do not consider it in its entirety (Miron-Shatz, 2009)

Article - Thomas, O. and Reimann, O. (2022). The bias blind spot among HR employees in hiring decisions. *German Journal of Human Resource Management Zeitschrift für Personalforschung*, 37(1), pp.5–22

Stereotyping



is the **perceptual process** in which we assign characteristics to an identifiable group and then automatically transfer those features to anyone we believe is a member of that group.

(McShane & Von Glinow, 2023)

Discrimination

- **Unintentional/systemic discrimination:** implicit, automatic, and unintentional

- **Intentional discrimination:** deliberately, negative, unfair

(McShane & Von Glinow, 2023)

Ethnic Bias In Recruitment

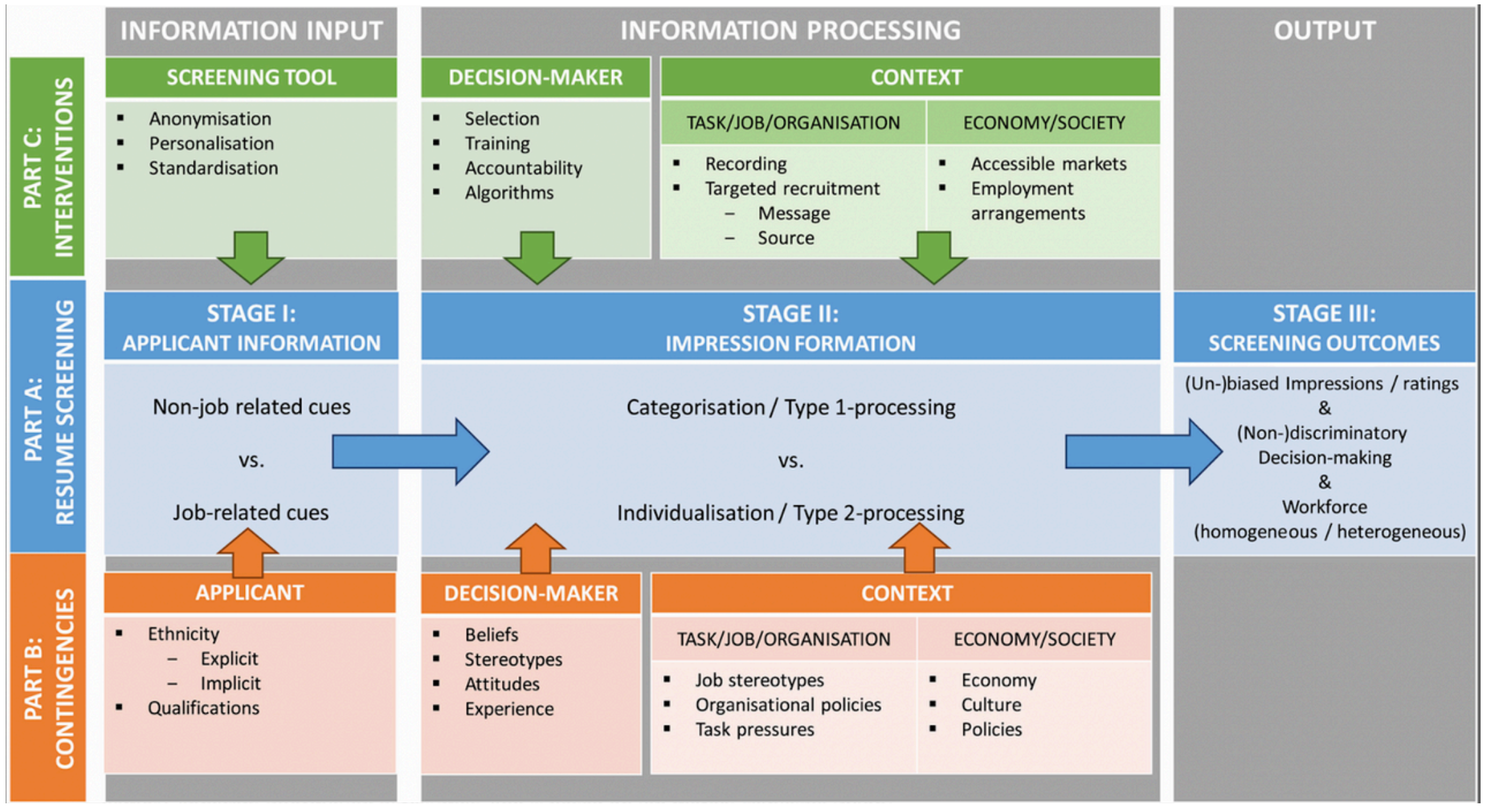
Ethnic minority candidates are often judged differently even when their qualifications are the same as majority applicants.

Research shows minority applicants must send about **50%** more applications to secure an interview compared with equally qualified majority applicants (Zschirnt & Ruedin, 2016). This reflects how subtle cues in resumes such as **names** can trigger biased evaluations.

These first impressions are not based on **ability** but on perceptions shaped by **stereotypes**.

Eva Derous and Ann Marie Ryan, (2018). When your resume is (not) turning you down: Modelling ethnic bias in resume screening. Human Resource Management Journal, 29(2), pp.113-130

How bias takes shape in resume screening



RESUME GAME

Education

- B.Com, University of Dublin, 2022 (GPA: 3.6/4.0)
- Relevant coursework: Corporate Finance, Business Analytics, Organizational Behaviour

Work Experience

- Finance Intern, ABC Bank (3 months): Assisted in preparing financial reports; conducted market research on retail banking trends
- Customer Service Associate, Tesco (2 years): Handled customer queries, managed transactions, and improved customer satisfaction scores

Skills

- Proficient in MS Excel, PowerPoint, and financial modeling basics
- Strong teamwork, analytical, and communication skills
- Languages: English (native), French (conversational)

Extracurricular Activities

- Treasurer, University Finance Society: Managed club budget and organized speaker events
- Volunteered at Dublin Food Bank during summer breaks

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Tackling biased screening

Several approaches can reduce the impact of ethnic bias in recruitment

Anonymisation

Concealing personal identifiers in resumes, as seen in blind auditions or “whitened” resumes, shifts focus to skills (Goldin & Rouse, 2000; Kang et al., 2016).

Standardisation

Structured application forms ensure more consistent evaluation and limit reliance on subjective impressions (Highhouse, Doverspike, & Guion, 2015).

Accountability

Using panels or diverse screening teams creates checks against individual bias and encourages more deliberate processing (Plant & Devine, 1998, 2009).

Algorithms

Data-driven tools, when designed carefully, can outperform human intuition and produce more reliable hiring decisions (Kuncel et al., 2013).

Perceptual bias based on gender

Our perception of a person's fit for a job, based solely on their gender

Stereotypes subconsciously create a notion of the archetypal person for the job

Article: Schaerer, M., du Plessis, C., Nguyen, M. H. B., van Aert, R. C. M., Tiokhin, L., Lakens, D., Giulia Clemente, E., Pfeiffer, T., Dreber, A., Johannesson, M., Clark, C. J., Luis Uhlmann, E., & Gender Audits Forecasting Collaboration. (2023). *On the trajectory of discrimination: A meta-analysis and forecasting survey capturing 44 years of field experiments on gender and hiring decisions*. Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes, 179, Article 104280.t

Female-Typed Jobs	Gender-Balanced Jobs	Male-Typed Jobs
Administrative clerk	Accountant	Auto mechanic
Executive secretary	Baker	Carpenter
Hairdresser	Barkeeper	Chef
HR professional	Call center worker	Computer specialist
Nurse	Commerce worker	Construction worker
Payroll clerk	Graphic designer	Electrician
Primary school teacher	Laboratory worker	Engineer
Receptionist	Marketing technician	Gardener
Social worker	Sales representative	Plumber
Waitstaff	Secondary school teacher	Truck driver

Schaerer et al (2023) pg. 7

Article: Schaerer, M., du Plessis, C., Nguyen, M. H. B., van Aert, R. C. M., Tiokhin, L., Lakens, D., Giulia Clemente, E., Pfeiffer, T., Dreber, A., Johannesson, M., Clark, C. J., Luis Uhlmann, E., & Gender Audits Forecasting Collaboration. (2023). *On the trajectory of discrimination: A meta-analysis and forecasting survey capturing 44 years of field experiments on gender and hiring decisions*. Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes, 179, Article 104280.t

Stereotypes = Mental shortcuts

Cues activate these stereotypes subconsciously

(Radvansky, Copeland and Hippel, 2009)

Purpose and Methodology

Article: Schaerer, M., du Plessis, C., Nguyen, M. H. B., van Aert, R. C. M., Tiokhin, L., Lakens, D., Giulia Clemente, E., Pfeiffer, T., Dreber, A., Johannesson, M., Clark, C. J., Luis Uhlmann, E., & Gender Audits Forecasting Collaboration. (2023). *On the trajectory of discrimination: A meta-analysis and forecasting survey capturing 44 years of field experiments on gender and hiring decisions*. Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes, 179, Article 104280.t

Findings

- **Male-type jobs**: historically biased against women. Bias has significantly decreased.
  - Women were more likely to receive a callback for a male-typed job (~10%).
- **Gender-balanced jobs:** historically biased against women. Bias has declined sharply.
- **Female-type jobs:** historically biased against males. Bias has remained present.
- **Overall:** discrimination has decreased, mainly discrimination against women. However, it is still present, but not in the way we might have thought.

Schaerer et al (2023)

Why do you think this happened?

Questions

Do you think stereotypical biases could be eliminated or through effective interventions, be reduced to a degree?

Do you think there is any level of objectivity in hiring or are biases overpowering hiring decisions?

From a consulting perspective, why should organisations invest in addressing biases beyond just ethics?

Are systemic biases indirectly or directly affecting organisations on a macro level in more ways than one?

Do you think social identity has anything to do with influencing or instigating individual biases?

THANK YOU!

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